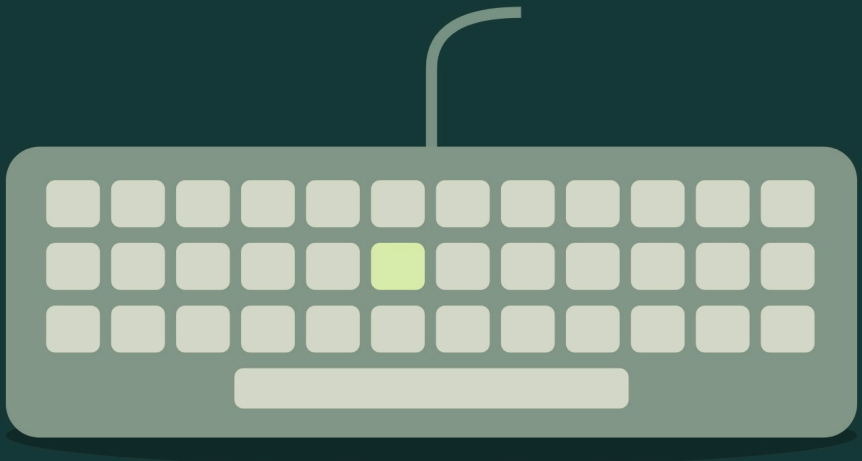
A PICK-YOUR-PATH COMEDY

Keyboard *Heist.*

Steal a keyboard just to feel something.



COMPANY PROPERTY

Nikhil Math

A PICK-YOUR-PATH COMEDY

Keyboard *Heist.*

Steal a keyboard just to feel something.

Nikhil Math

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Don’t read this book front to back. Start at Section 1.

At the end of each section, pick what you’ll do next. On a screen, click or tap your choice. On paper, turn to the section number it gives: every section starts on a new page with its number at the top.

The sections are shuffled on purpose. The page after a section is never the next part of your story, so follow your choice instead of turning the page. To undo a click, use your PDF reader’s Back button.

Some choices are stamped SIN or VIRTUE. Pay attention to them.

Some paths reach a real ending: “The end.” Others hit a dead end, which sends you back to try a different choice. There are eleven real endings and three dead ends.

Begin at Section 1.

CONTENTS

How to read this book

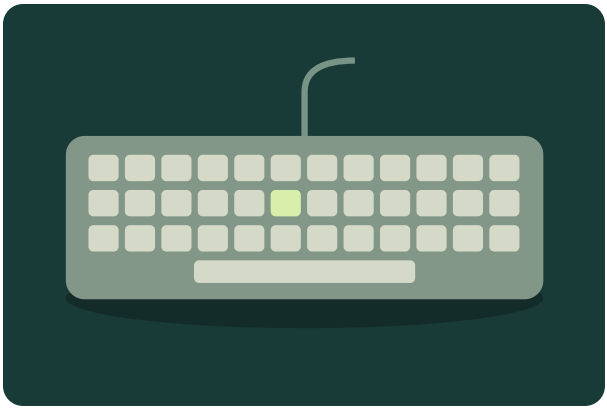
Section 1: start here

The endings

Every section, by number:

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32
33	34	35	36	37	38	39	40
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49	50	51	52	53	54	55	56
57	58	59	60	61	62	63	64
65	66	67	68	69	70	71	72
73	74						

Section 1



Quick printer help? :)

You're the IT Support Manager. You've spent the last few months waking up, fixing problems, going home, and waiting until it's reasonable to go to bed. Nothing is especially wrong. Nothing is especially interesting. You've reached the plateau, apparently, and the view is mostly Outlook.

Then a ticket pops up...

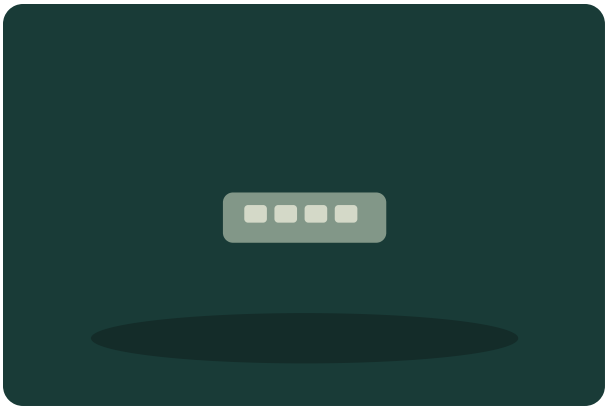
> **From:** Daniel Hall, CEO
>
> **Subject:** Quick printer help? :)
>
> Hey! Having trouble getting the new printer working. Think it needs a driver? Whenever you have a minute. Appreciate you!

A printer driver. You hate those.

What will you do?

- **Head to his office.** TURN TO 34
- **Reply, "Have you tried restarting the printer?"** TURN TO 47
- **Look up the printer's model in inventory.** TURN TO 23

Section 2



Take it. Right now.

You pick it up. It weighs almost nothing. You walk out holding it in both hands, like a casserole.

Daniel is in the hallway, phone already lowered. “Oh! What are you doing with that?”

“It’s not working,” you say. “I’ll grab you a different one.”

“Oh no, that happened before!” He’s delighted to help. “Just unplug the little receiver and plug it back in. Don’t even need to reset anything.”

He does it for you, right there in the hallway. It works. Of course it works. “Honestly, keep it! I’ve got a spare in a drawer.” He holds it out to you with both hands.

It slips. It hits the floor. The space bar skates down the hall. Something inside makes a small, final sound.

Daniel looks at it. “Oh. Never mind. I’ll use the spare.”

You go back to your desk, where Outlook is waiting.

You step away for coffee. When you come back, it’s on your desk, the space bar in a sandwich bag. A Post-it in Daniel’s handwriting: “Can you save him?”

You’re IT. Broken things come to you. You open it up. One spring, knocked loose. You put it back. You click the space bar on. You could tell

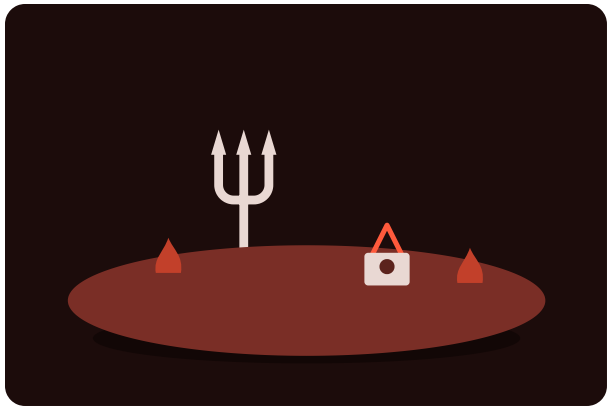
Daniel it's dead and keep it. Nobody would ever know.

You walk it back to his office instead. He plugs it in with a cable this time, "so he can't get away again," and offers you his chair to test it. You type your name. It still feels wonderful.

What will you do?

Go home. Try not to think about it. TURN TO 72

Section 3



Swap it at the huddle. Hide the real one in the Lake of Fire.

You swap them at the huddle, on hug four, and drop the real one in the Lake of Fire until the count is over.

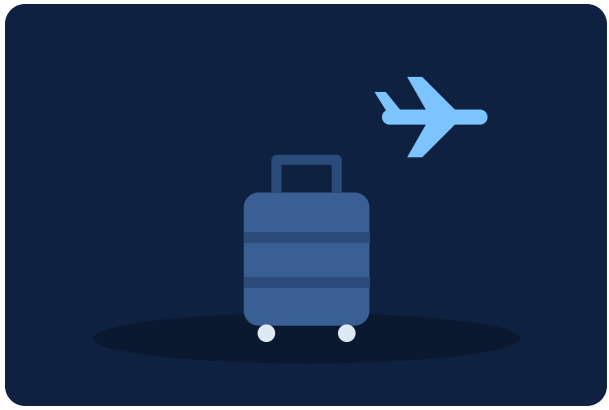
The count goes by serial number. Your decoy doesn't have one. Everyone goes looking. Pitchforks are fireproof. So, it turns out, are lanyards. Yours caught on the prongs. It's floating face up, with your photo.

Compliance writes you up and assigns you to Lost and Found, until further notice. In Hell, there is no further notice.

What will you do?

Report to Lost and Found. TURN TO 46

Section 4



Pick her up at the airport.

Your mom comes through arrivals with one carry-on. She looks at you for about two seconds. “Oh, honey,” she says. “You’re bored.”

You tell her everything, right there by baggage claim: Daniel, the keyboard, the decoy, the grandmother you almost hired. She doesn’t look shocked. She looks interested.

“I’ve been bored since I retired,” she says. “Nothing’s especially wrong. Nothing’s especially interesting.” So it runs in the family.

The long visit lasts forty minutes. She has already bought you a seat on her flight home.

That night, in her kitchen in Ohio, she tells you about the moon rock at the Armstrong Air & Space Museum in Wapakoneta, half an hour away. A real piece of the Moon, from Apollo 11. She first saw it on a school trip when she was eight. She has wanted it ever since.

What will you do?

Go in with a school field trip. TURN TO 53

Go in at closing time. TURN TO 50

Section 5



Put the keyboard back. Fix the toilet.

You Velcro the keyboard back to the wall. Then you take the panel off the toilet.

Houston talks you through it. Something small is jammed in the fan. You don't ask what. You get it out. The fan spins. Nobody shakes your hand. Everybody thanks you.

That night, Orion swings behind the Moon. There's no signal back there. No Houston. No Daniel. No Outlook.

Your mom holds the moon rock up to the window, right next to the Moon. "Look," she says. "It's home."

Nothing is especially wrong. Everything is especially interesting.

The end.

ENDING: THE FAR SIDE

Start over at Section 1.

Section 6



Sell him Daniel's keyboard.

The Devil types his name on Daniel's keyboard. Then again. "Oh," he says. "Oh, I see." He signs before you can change your mind.

A pitchfork given for keeps comes with its owner's job. It's in the bylaws. A headset arrives from Ohio with a note: "Gosh! First vacation since the Bronze Age!"

Your desk faces a wall of monitors. On every one, an IT Support Manager is reading "Driver unavailable." You tap a key with the pitchfork. A printer in Tulsa stops working.

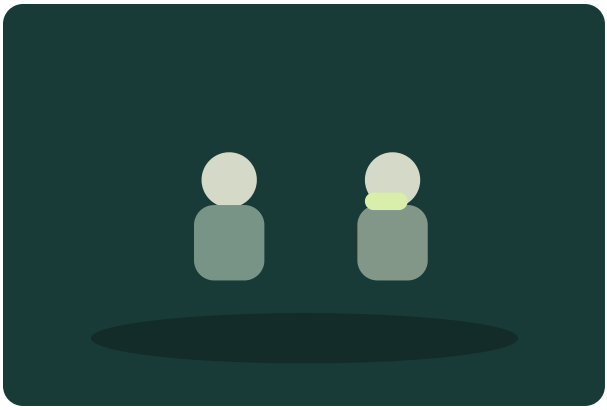
You hate printer drivers, and you are extraordinary at this. You just weren't expecting to do it for the rest of your life.

The end.

ENDING: DRIVER UNAVAILABLE

Start over at Section 1.

Section 7



The resignation

You send it. Your heart does something it hasn't done in months.

Thirty seconds later your phone rings. "Oh my gosh. Are you okay? Is it the printer?"

Daniel is at your desk in ninety seconds. He pulls up the visitor chair. He listens for two hours. He does not once look at his phone.

He offers a sabbatical, a raise, a therapist named Carol, and a granola bar. "I'd rather lose a printer than a person," he says.

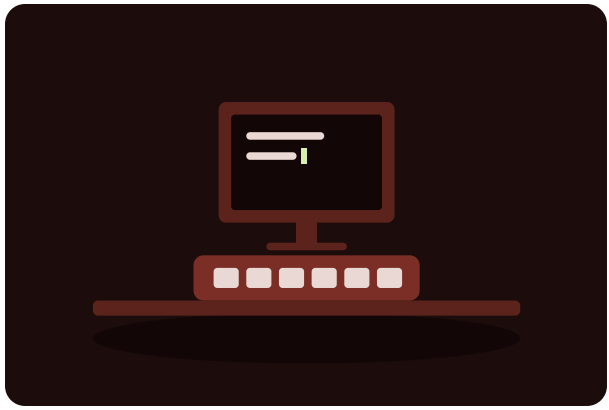
You could take it. You could take it back.

What will you do?

Take the sabbatical. TURN TO 59

Say it was a typo. TURN TO 20

Section 8



Give back the inhaler. Then the keyboard.

You slide back into the office on your knees and press the inhaler into the auditor's hand. While he breathes, you set the real keyboard back on Daniel's desk and slip the decoy into your bag. Nobody sees. Nobody ever will.

That night, at the kitchen table, you type your name on the decoy. It feels like a keyboard. It always did.

But Daniel started a company on his. Some of his soul got into it, and that's what you wanted to steal. Nobody has put anything into this one yet.

So you'll make something on it. You don't know what. Something with enough of you in it that one day, somebody will want to steal it.

You type a second line. Nobody asked for it. That's the point.

The end.

ENDING: YOUR OWN KEYBOARD

Start over at Section 1.

Section 9



The lie

You slide back into the office on your knees. You press the inhaler into his hand. “You dropped this,” you say. “Ten seconds ago. I saw it.”

He breathes. He breathes again. He nods, eyes wet. He believes you completely.

He sits against the desk. He sees the keyboard in your arms. “Why did you grab the keyboard?” “I don’t know,” you say. “I wasn’t thinking about it. I just had it.”

It’s almost true. He decides what it means. “You grabbed what was in your hands and you came back,” he says, like he’s explaining you to yourself. He assumes you would never have let him die over a keyboard. That lands harder than the inhaler.

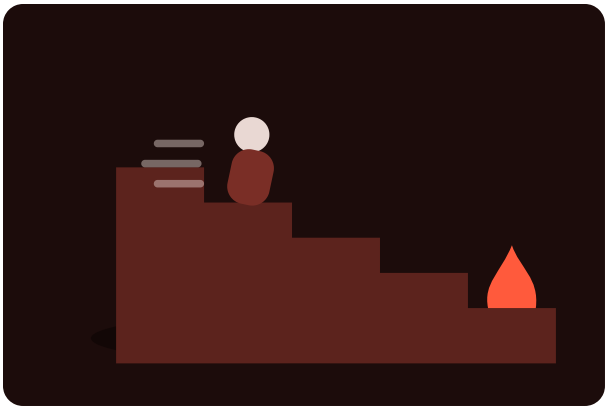
By evening, everyone knows about the inhaler. Nobody knows about the keyboard, which is in your bag. You should feel guilty. You do. You rationalize: the company wants happy employees. You are an employee. You are happy. Aren’t you?

Your phone buzzes. Daniel: “Heard what you did today. Thank you. You saved a man’s life.”

What will you do?

Go home. TURN TO 38

Section 10



Keep running.

You keep running. Past Marcy and her granola bar. Down the stairs: lobby, basement, B2, which the building doesn't have. B9. It gets warm. Then very warm.

At the bottom, a sign: WELCOME TO HELL, PLEASE TAKE A NUMBER. A demon at the front desk prints you a lanyard. "You're early. Most people die first. The auditor will be fine, by the way. You didn't know that when you ran."

"Bring the keyboard. Orientation is at nine. And yes, the running is already on your record."

What will you do?

SIN **Sign in. Keep the keyboard.** TURN TO 33

VIRTUE **Run back up and face it.** TURN TO 57

Section 11



The garage

Thirty minutes later, he's still going. You know about the kayak shop. You know about his first customer, a dentist named Phil, and Phil's very specific ideas about fonts.

"You know what?" Daniel says. He looks at the keyboard. "I've had it long enough. I think it's time."

He holds it out to you with both hands. It's the thing you wanted. He's just giving it to you.

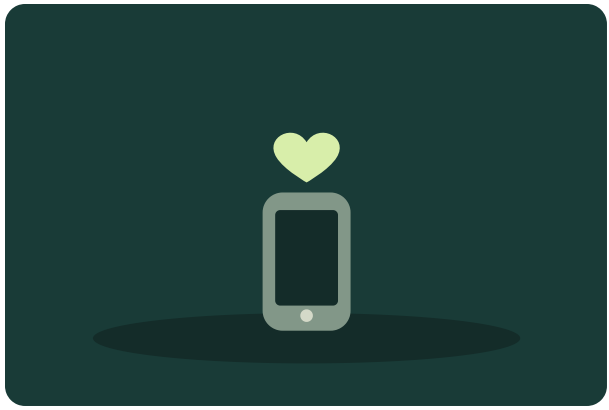
What will you do?

Take it. TURN TO 60

Borrow it for the weekend. TURN TO 37

Say you couldn't possibly. TURN TO 43

Section 12



Forget it. Use your mother in Ohio.

You tell Daniel your mother is very sick. He is stricken. He is also thorough: he asks for her number, so he can pray with her.

She picks up on the first ring. She is fine. She is also confused. Daniel prays for three minutes. She says “Amen,” because she is polite.

She calls you back at six. “Who is Daniel and why is he so nice to me? Are you okay?”

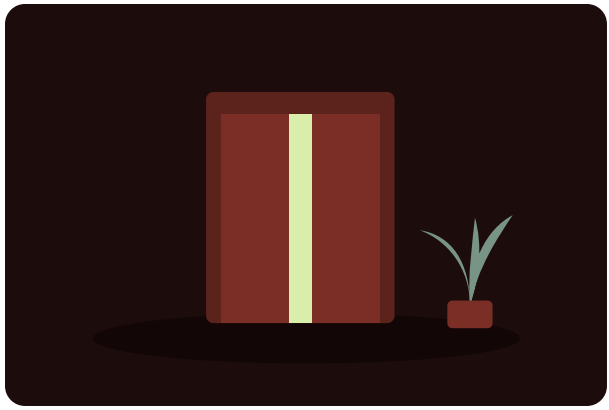
She’s coming for a long visit. She has already booked the flight. The keyboard is still on Daniel’s desk.

Daniel tells you to take all the time you need. “Family comes first,” he says, with a hand over his heart.

What will you do?

Pick her up at the airport. TURN TO 4

Section 13



Return to sender

The elevator has one button. The doors open next to the fern. The clock says 11:19, the minute you ran. Up here, none of it has happened yet.

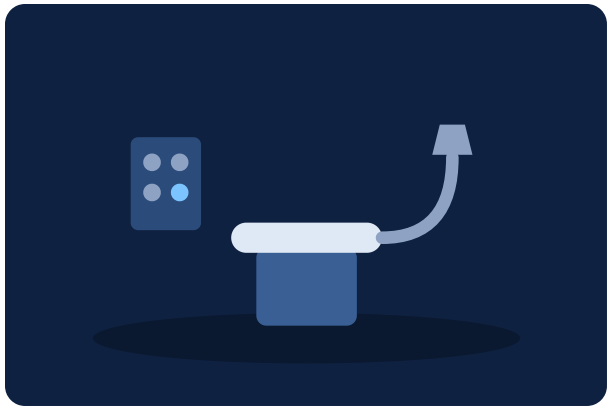
The keyboard is in your arms. The inhaler is under your shoe. Somewhere behind you, a man is wheezing.

What will you do?

Go back with the inhaler. TURN TO 9

Give back the inhaler. Then the keyboard. TURN TO 8

Section 14



Let your mom distract them.

Your mom has questions. How do you sleep? How do you eat? How does the bathroom work?

The astronauts are polite, because she is. They give her a tour of the toilet. She asks what one button does. All four of them say “Don’t.”

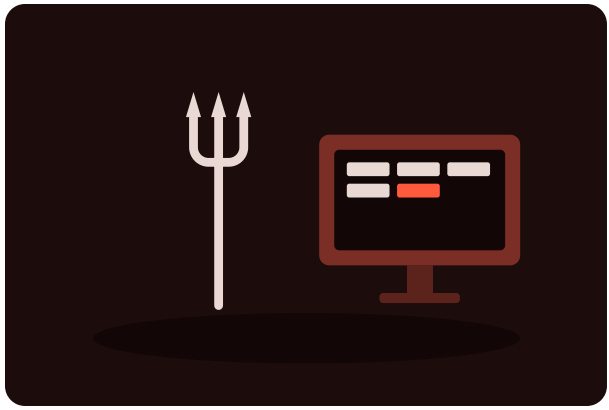
She has already pressed it. The toilet makes a noise like a blender eating a spoon. Then it makes no noise at all.

While everyone stares at the toilet, you peel the keyboard off the wall. Velcro is very loud. Nobody hears it.

What will you do?

Hide it behind your back. TURN TO 64

Section 15



The plan, again

Hell gives you a cubicle. You can't stop thinking about the pitchfork.

There's a bin of spares by the elevator. You take one and poke the air. Nothing. It has to be theirs. Well. Now you have a decoy.

Every day at three, the nice demon leans their pitchfork on a table at the Torment Huddle to hug people. Every night, Compliance counts.

What will you do?

SIN **Swap it at the huddle. Hide the real one in the Lake of Fire.** TURN TO 3

VIRTUE **Just ask for it.** TURN TO 61

Section 16



Report him.

You tell him you're going to report him. He isn't worried. He's never worried.

"Oh, you absolutely can," he says. "But there's no way for me to get caught. There never has been."

He turns his monitor toward you. Eleven years of invoices. Every one of them is now signed with your name.

You typed it into his keyboard yourself, that first day in his office. Twice.

You're the fall guy. So now you sit at your desk and say nothing, and hope nobody else ever looks closely enough to catch him, because if they do, they'll catch you.

Maybe you shouldn't have taken that ticket.

Every ending is another beginning.

DEAD END: THE FALL GUY

Try a different choice. TURN BACK TO 30

Section 17



Grab your mom. Take the escape pod.

The escape pod has two seats, one parachute and no instructions.

Your mom leaves the moon rock on the commander's seat with a note: "Sorry about the toilet." It's closer to home up here anyway. Then she climbs in.

The pod swings once around the Moon and falls toward Earth. The keyboard is in your lap. Your mom is laughing. You realize you are too.

Three days later, you splash down in Lake Erie. A fishing boat picks you up. The captain doesn't ask. Ohio doesn't ask.

What will you do?

Take it home. TURN TO 21

Section 18



Skip it. Nobody checks.

You skip the tag. You do the swap at lunch. Nobody checks, you tell yourself.

The auditor checks. He scans the keyboard on Daniel's desk. It beeps once. Red. "Asset not found," says the scanner, very calmly.

He looks at the keyboard. He looks at you. He has seen this before, and he is sad about it. He calls Daniel in.

Daniel arrives holding a granola bar. He looks at the keyboard, then at you. He is heartbroken. "I would've just given it to you." You are asked to leave. The real keyboard was in your bag the whole time. It feels like nothing.

Every ending is another beginning.

DEAD END: ASSET NOT FOUND

Try a different choice. TURN BACK TO 48

Section 19



Say you’re just tired.

“Just tired,” you say. Jordan doesn’t believe you, but they let it go this time, and the next time, and the time after that.

You keep letting things go. Eventually there’s nothing left to hold.

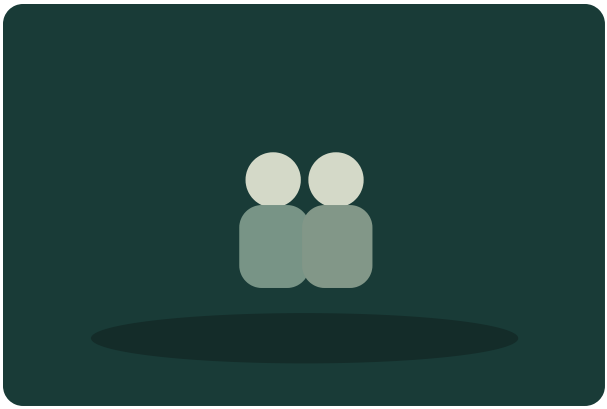
Two months later, Jordan’s toothbrush is gone from the bathroom, and you don’t remember watching them take it. You just notice the empty cup where it stood.

You cry once, brief and confusing. Then a ticket pops up: Daniel, the printer, again. “Whenever you have a minute. Appreciate you!”

What will you do?

Think about something else. TURN TO 34

Section 20



Say it was a typo.

“It was a typo,” you say.

Daniel reads the email. It says, in full, “Dear Daniel, I quit.” He looks at you for a long moment. “A typo,” he says gently. “Okay.”

He doesn’t believe you. He hugs you anyway. He smells like granola.

It was the best ninety seconds you’ve had in a long time, and you didn’t even leave. You want to feel it again. You’re not sure how.

What will you do?

Figure out how. TURN TO 72

Section 21



Take it home.

Your mom's computer is older than some of your coworkers. The keyboard that went around the Moon plugs right in.

She types her bingo newsletter on it. You type your name. It feels wonderful. You're pretty sure it isn't the keyboard.

She reads the newsletter out loud, doing voices. You laugh until you have to sit on the floor. The refrigerator hums. Nobody minds.

Daniel texts to ask how your mother is doing. "Better," you write back. "So am I."

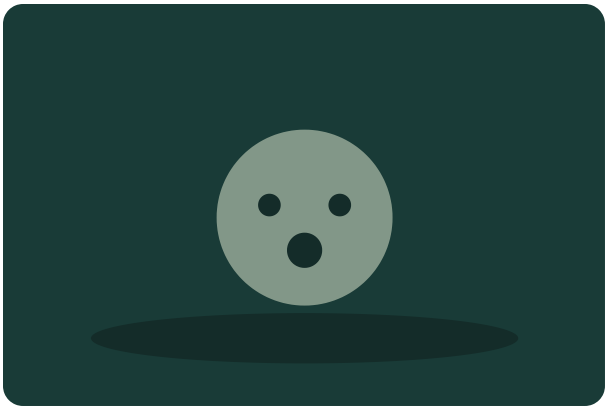
You didn't need a keyboard. You needed a little spice.

The end.

ENDING: A LITTLE SPICE

Start over at Section 1.

Section 22



Tell him no.

You tell him no.

He blinks. Nobody's ever told him no. Not once in eleven years, and not once in the several centuries before that.

His face does something you've never seen it do. It stops being delighted. For a moment it's only surprised.

"Huh," says Danal, seventh and most evil wizard of Xeon.

You walk back to your desk. The keyboard stays where it is. You don't look at it.

It's the first interesting thing that's happened to either of you in years.

The end.

ENDING: THE FIRST NO

Start over at Section 1.

Section 23



Look up the printer’s model in inventory.

You look up the printer’s model. It’s one you’ve fixed a hundred times. You find the driver, push it to Daniel’s laptop, and the printer wakes up with a small, proud beep.

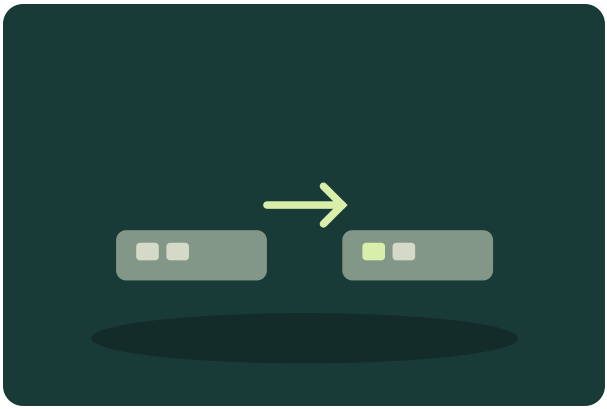
Ticket closed at 4:52. You’re very good at your job.

Daniel replies in nine seconds. “You’re a lifesaver!! Come by, I want to thank you in person. I have a granola bar for you!”

What will you do?

Head to his office. TURN TO 34

Section 24



The swap

The supply closet. An asset tag is a barcode and a serial number. You copy one, change a digit, and add the new number to the asset list. IT has the password. The night cleaner asks if you're working late. "Inventory." He does not ask about the barcode.

The auditor arrives at nine sharp with a scanner, a clipboard, and a face like an unopened envelope. He counts everything twice. He likes you. You're the only one who answers his questions with numbers, which is worse.

You give him the tour, steering him away from Daniel's office. He steers back. It is the last item on his list. You get there first.

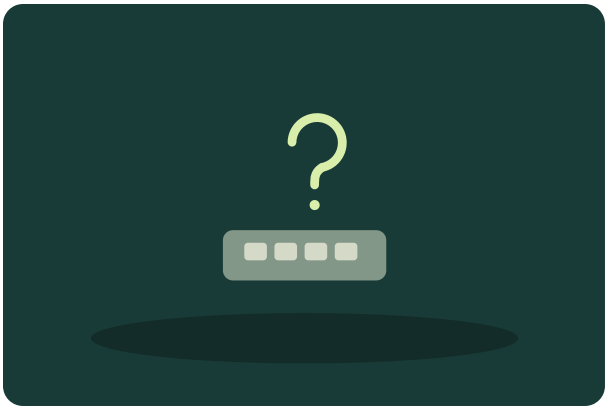
The office is empty. The decoy goes on the desk. The real keyboard goes on the chair, for a second, while you straighten the cable. Footsteps. The auditor is in the doorway, scanner up.

He scans the keyboard on the desk. The forged tag beeps green. You have never been prouder of anything. "Well," he says. He stops. He puts a hand to his chest. He starts to wheeze.

What will you do?

Look at him. TURN TO 26

Section 25



Just ask him about it.

You ask Daniel where he got the keyboard, in the most innocent voice you own.

He lights up like you've asked about his kids. "Oh, gosh, this old thing? Sit. Sit!"

He bought it in a garage, on a Tuesday, for $150, with a partner who quit two years later to open a kayak shop. He typed his first invoice on it. He has typed every invoice since.

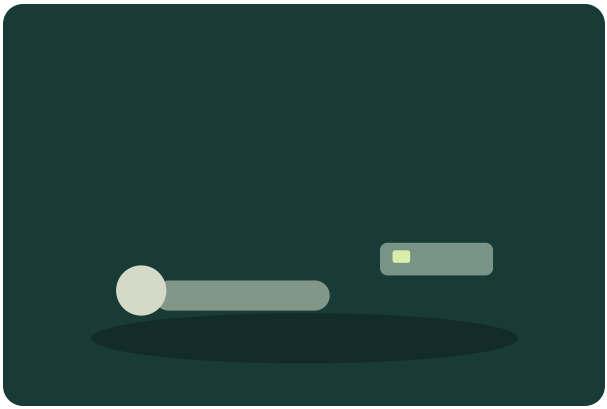
He talks to you like you're a person, not a ticket number. Somewhere in your bag, the decoy is very, very quiet.

What will you do?

Let him finish. TURN TO 11

Ask if you could have it. TURN TO 60

Section 26



The choice

He drops to one knee. His scanner clatters. He's gasping like a man who's run out of a word.

The keyboard is on the chair behind you. He's on the floor now. For one second, you look at the keyboard.

You are shocked. Shocked that you looked at it at all. That it took you a whole second to look back at him. You feel guilty in a way you didn't know you could.

You grab the keyboard and run anyway. Down the hall, past a fern and a poster that says TEAMWORK. Something skitters under your shoe. You look down. It's an inhaler.

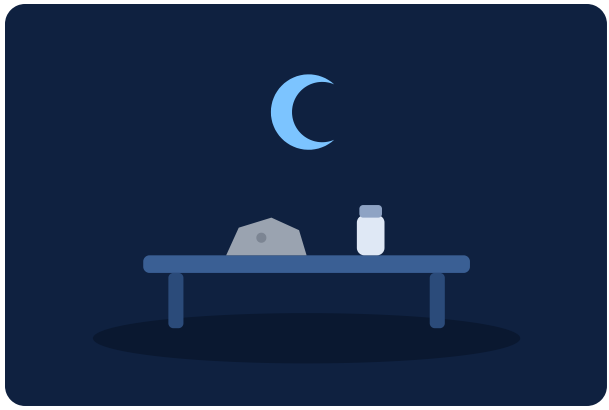
"Dang," you say.

What will you do?

VIRTUE **Go back with the inhaler.** TURN TO 9

SIN **Keep running.** TURN TO 10

Section 27



The rock

The moon rock sits on your mom's kitchen table, next to the salt. You both look at it for a long time. "It's a rock," she says. You know this feeling. You paid $149.99 for it once.

On the TV in the next room, Artemis II launches from Florida in nine days: four astronauts, once around the Moon and home. The camera tours the capsule. Strapped to the wall with Velcro is a keyboard.

Everything NASA buys is the best one ever made, tested past the point of reason. That is the best keyboard on or off the planet.

Your mom turns the TV up. "They don't keep the good stuff in Ohio," she says, and drops the moon rock in her purse. It goes where she goes now.

You started with a CEO. Now it's the government. Out of habit, you check the IT contract boards. Kennedy Space Center has posted a printer-driver ticket.

What will you do?

Take the printer-driver ticket. TURN TO 49

Hide in the cargo. TURN TO 56

Section 28



Walk out and pretend you never saw it.

You don’t say anything. You just stand up and walk out.

He doesn’t stop you. From the hallway you can hear him humming.

By lunch you’ve decided that none of it happened. There’s no realm. There’s no Xeon. There’s a nice man with a good keyboard, and it’s sitting on his desk where you can see it.

You still want it. That’s the part that doesn’t go away.

What will you do?

Get back to the plan. TURN TO 65

Section 29



Liftoff

Zero. The whole world shakes for eight minutes. Somewhere in the dark, your mom finds your hand and holds it the entire time. You haven't held her hand since you were nine.

Then it goes quiet. A pen floats past your face. Then one of your mom's sandwiches.

The astronauts find you about an hour later. There's a lot of language. The commander calls Houston, and Houston is quiet for a very long time.

You can't turn a moon rocket around. They give you a corner, two straps and one rule: don't touch anything.

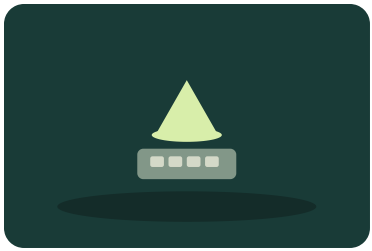
It takes five days to reach the Moon. The keyboard is on the wall the whole way, six feet from you.

What will you do?

Wait until they sleep. TURN TO 52

Let your mom distract them. TURN TO 14

Section 30



Take it back to him.

You put it on his desk and tell him what it did. You rehearsed this on the drive in. You're expecting panic.

He lights up. "Oh, good! I was hoping it would like you."

He explains it cheerfully, the same way he told you the garage story. Except he never bought it in a garage. He found it there, already typing. He hasn't done any actual work in eleven years. The company is real, the money is real, and the work was never real.

His name also isn't Daniel Hall. It is Danal, seventh and most evil wizard of Xeon, a realm from which unwavering capitalism was first spawned. He mentions this while hunting for the granola bars.

"That's money laundering," you say. "Is it?" he says, delighted, as though you've taught him something. "Do I still call you Daniel?" you ask. "Oh, please do. I love it here."

He's evil the way a spreadsheet is evil. He's never once had a single thing to worry about. That's what you've been looking at this whole time. That's the face you wanted. "It could be yours," he says.

What will you do?

Ask him to show you. TURN TO 74

Tell him no. TURN TO 22

Report him. TURN TO 16

Walk out and pretend you never saw it. TURN TO 28

Section 31



Go look.

The keyboard is typing. Nothing is touching it. The screen is filling up.

Invoices. Client names you've never heard. Amounts with too many digits. Every one of them dated next Tuesday.

You look up the companies. None of them exist.

You add the amounts, because you're the kind of person who adds the amounts. It comes to just under a hundred million dollars.

It has typed every invoice since the garage. Daniel told you that himself. He was proud of it.

What will you do?

Take it back to him. TURN TO 30

Section 32



Stand up. Walk away. Never think about this again.

You say goodbye to Daniel. You say goodbye to the keyboard, silently, like an idiot.

You go home. You do not think about it. You think about it in the shower. You think about it at dinner.

Back at your desk, you open a blank email and type: “Dear Daniel, I quit.” It feels wonderful.

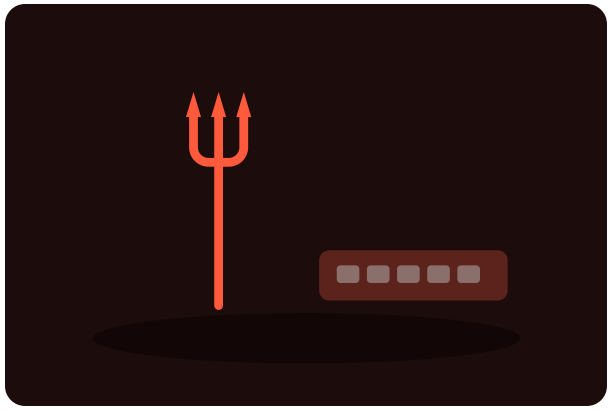
You backspace it. You type it again. Your cursor hovers over Send.

What will you do?

Send it. TURN TO 7

Save it as a draft. TURN TO 67

Section 33



Orientation

Orientation: no windows, a hum someone chose on purpose, deviled eggs. Compliance counts the chairs twice and opens a file with your name on it.

The demon who brought the eggs is so happy you're here their tail wags. The nicest demon in Hell, everyone says, a little tiredly. They hand you their pitchfork to "get a feel for it" during the safety video.

The handle is warm. The balance is perfect. You poke the air, and the air seems grateful. The keyboard under your other arm feels like nothing now. Uh oh.

What will you do?

SIN **Steal it. Walk out.** TURN TO 42

VIRTUE **Hand it back. Smile.** TURN TO 15

Section 34



Head to his office.

Forty-three seconds to Daniel's office. His door is open, because his door is always open.

He looks up and his whole face reorganizes into welcome. "Hey! Gosh, thanks for coming down. Did you eat? I have a granola bar."

You did eat. You decline. He apologizes for the ticket, for the printer, for having a printer at all.

There's a Bible verse on a Post-it stuck to his monitor. A framed photo of his kids on the desk.

He offers you his chair. His phone lights up. "Sorry, gotta grab this. Holler if you need anything." He steps out. The door doesn't quite close.

You put your hands on the keyboard because your hands have to go somewhere.

You type your name. It's a nothing keyboard, the kind companies buy in bulk for executives. You type your name again.

You've been typing on keyboards for twenty-two years. You have never noticed a keyboard before. You are noticing this keyboard.

You type a whole sentence: "Something is wrong with me." You backspace it. The backspace also feels wonderful.

Daniel is still on the phone. Your hands are still on the keyboard.

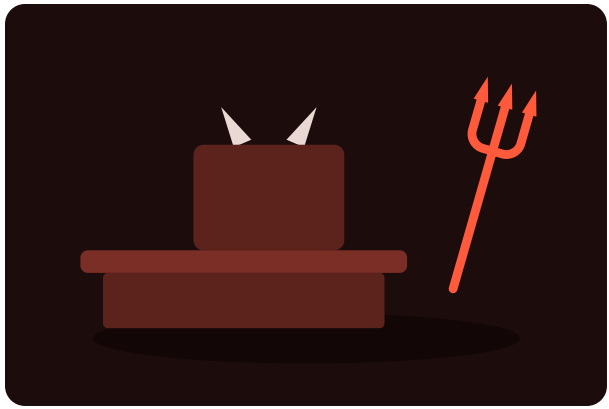
What will you do?

Take it. Right now. TURN TO 2

Leave it. Come back for it later. TURN TO 72

Stand up. Walk away. Never think about this again. TURN TO 32

Section 35



The Devil's offer

The next morning, the Devil calls you in. "I hear you asked. Nobody asks." He's holding the nice demon's pitchfork. "Yours, no job attached. I wrote the bylaws. I can skip a page."

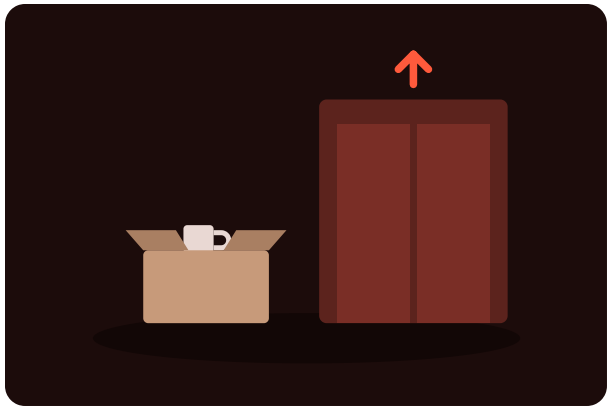
They'll get a new one, he says. He doesn't want your soul. He's seen it, and it's mostly Outlook. His eyes drift to the keyboard under your arm.

What will you do?

SIN **Trade him Daniel's keyboard.** TURN TO 41

VIRTUE **Say no. Give it all back.** TURN TO 69

Section 36



Say nothing. Let them take the fall.

You say nothing. You're better at this than you should be.

In the morning, the nice demon packs a mug that says WORLD'S OKAYEST DEMON and hugs you goodbye. It takes a while. They mean it.

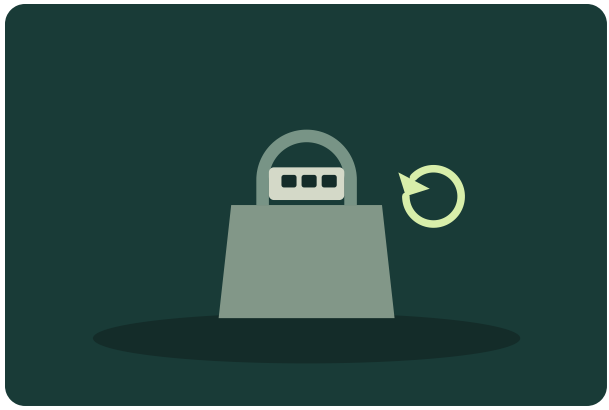
The pitchfork is yours now, unofficially. Every night you hide it from the count. It won't be yours for real unless somebody signs it over.

What will you do?

SIN **Make a deal with the Devil.** TURN TO 73

VIRTUE **Confess on Form 666. Bring them back.** TURN TO 71

Section 37



Borrow it for the weekend.

You take it home for the weekend. You type your name. You type the alphabet. You type a very short letter to nobody. Nothing.

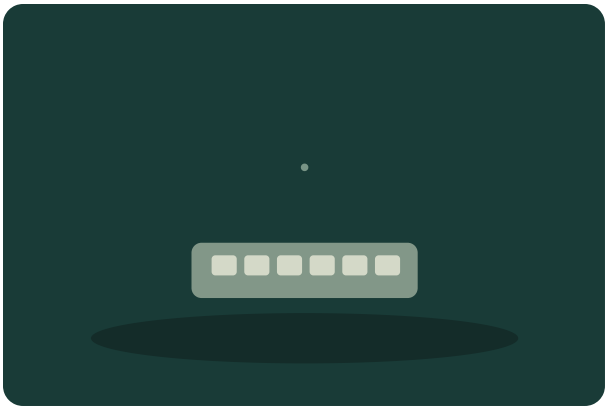
On Monday, you carry it back. “How was it?” Daniel asks. “Fine,” you say. “It’s a keyboard.” He laughs, delighted, as if you’ve said something profound.

He sets it back on his desk. The second it’s his again, you want it again. That’s worse.

What will you do?

Back to the plan. TURN TO 65

Section 38



The plateau

You walk out with it in your bag. Past Marcy. Past the fern. Nobody stops you. Nobody checks. On Daniel's desk, the decoy is already answering his emails. He hasn't noticed. He never will.

At home, you take it out of the bag and set it on the kitchen table. You plug it in. Nobody is cheering. The refrigerator hums.

You type your name. It appears on the screen. It feels like a keyboard. It always did. What you felt in Daniel's office was never the keyboard.

You wait for the rest of it. The part where it was worth it. You give it a minute. You give it a week.

That was the whole thing. That was all of it.

Nothing is especially wrong. Nothing is especially interesting. You've reached the plateau, apparently, and the view is mostly Outlook.

The end.

ENDING: THE PLATEAU

Start over at Section 1.

Section 39



The ceremony

Forty people clap. Marcy, Daniel's assistant, made a banner. It says CONGRATULATIONS, ROB. Your name is not Rob.

Daniel hands you a plaque and a granola bar. "Would you like to say a few words?"

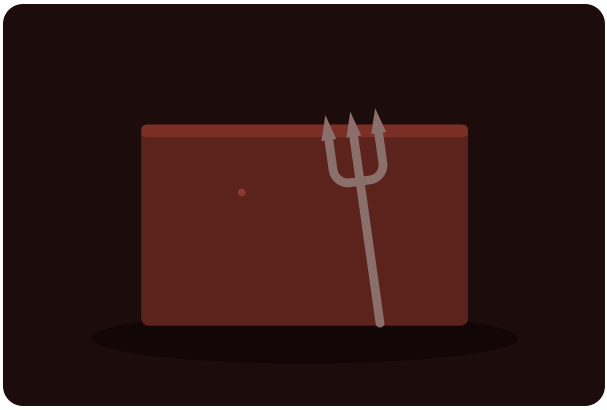
The whole room is looking at you with its whole face. It's the most attention you've had in years. You wait to feel it.

What will you do?

Say a few words. TURN TO 45

Say "thank you" and sit down. TURN TO 66

Section 40



The lower plateau

One good deed, a little late. Down here, that counts for exactly nothing. Nobody is cheering. The Lake of Fire hums.

You get a cubicle and a lot of Tuesdays. Somewhere, a pitchfork leans against a wall. It feels like a pitchfork. It always did. What you felt at orientation was never the pitchfork.

You wait for the rest of it. You give it a thousand years.

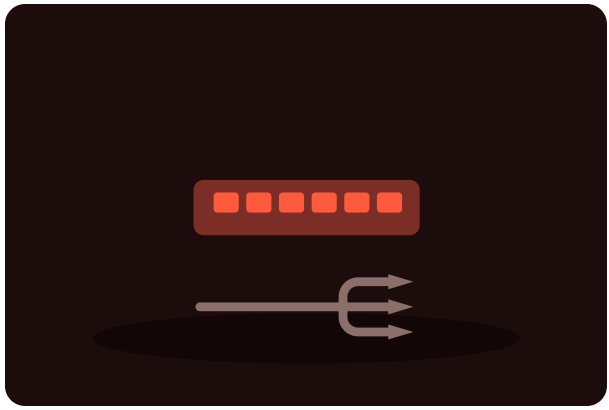
Nothing is especially wrong. Nothing is especially interesting. You've reached the plateau again, a little lower this time, and the view is mostly the Lake of Fire.

The end.

ENDING: THE LOWER PLATEAU

Start over at Section 1.

Section 41



Trade him Daniel’s keyboard.

The Devil types his name on Daniel’s keyboard. Then again. “Oh,” he says. “Oh, I see.”

By lunch, the pitchfork is yours, fair and square, with a receipt. You poke the air. Nothing. It only ever felt like something when it wasn’t yours.

Through the open door, the Devil is still typing his name. You stand in the hallway, listening to someone else be happy.

What will you do?

Drop it at Lost and Found. TURN TO 46

Section 42



Steal it. Walk out.

You walk out of the safety video holding the pitchfork, like you have somewhere to be. Nobody stops you.

That night, Compliance counts. One pitchfork is missing. The nice demon pats every pocket twice. “Losing an implement is a transfer offense,” Compliance says. “Up. Middle management. Ohio.” They have until morning.

What will you do?

SIN **Say nothing. Let them take the fall.** TURN TO 36

VIRTUE **Give it back before morning.** TURN TO 55

Section 43



Say you couldn’t possibly.

You say you couldn’t possibly. Daniel insists. You say it again. It costs you more than you expected.

He puts it back on the desk, a little hurt, and hands you a granola bar to make up for it.

In your bag, the decoy has never felt heavier. You eat the granola bar. It’s a really good granola bar.

You’re still doing this. You’re just going to feel worse about it.

What will you do?

Back to the plan. TURN TO 65

Section 44



See them again.

Three weeks in, you know Jordan's coffee order, their sister's name, the fact that they cry at commercials but not at anything that's actually sad.

It's good. It's better than good. You keep noticing that you're not bored, which is its own kind of strange, like finding a room in your house you didn't know was there.

Then one night, half listening to a story about Jordan's sister's wedding, you notice the old feeling creeping back in. The plateau. The one from before all of this.

Jordan notices you've gone somewhere else. "Where'd you go?" they ask.

What will you do?

Tell them everything. TURN TO 54

Say you're just tired. TURN TO 19

Section 45



Say a few words.

You say, “I’ve been really bored for a long time.” The room goes silent.

Then everyone laughs. Someone whoops. Daniel wipes his eyes. “Oh my gosh, you’re so funny.” You get a standing ovation. Forty people believe it was a joke.

Jordan, from Accounts Payable, doesn’t believe it. They wait until the room clears, then find you at your desk. “I wasn’t laughing,” they say.

You don’t know what to say back. For once, that’s fine.

What will you do?

Get a drink after work. TURN TO 68

Section 46



Lost and Found

Lost and Found is a folding table at the edge of the Lake of Fire. Everything Hell loses ends up here eventually. Car keys. Left socks. A pitchfork nobody claims.

You sort the socks by size. You alphabetize the umbrellas. Somehow, you work here now.

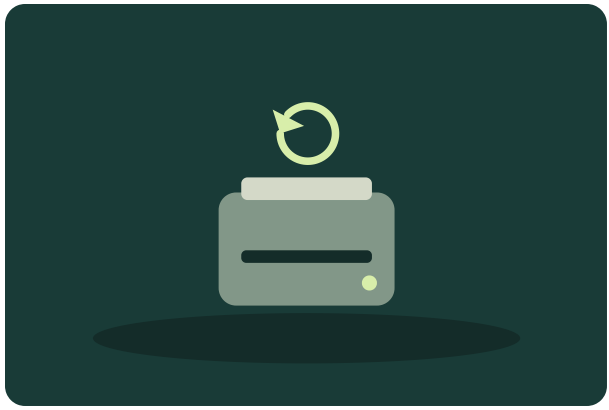
Nobody ever comes to claim anything, including you.

The end.

ENDING: LOST AND FOUND

Start over at Section 1.

Section 47



Have you tried restarting the printer?

Daniel replies in eleven seconds. “Oh! Good idea!” A minute later: “That worked!! You’re a genius. Appreciate you!”

The ticket closes at 4:49 p.m. It took no skill at all.

Then, a second email, all staff: “Please join me Friday at 3 p.m. in congratulating our IT Support Manager, Employee of the Month! There will be granola bars.”

You have never won anything. You have never wanted to.

What will you do?

Go to the ceremony. TURN TO 39

Call in sick Friday. TURN TO 51

Section 48



The audit

You paid Mrs. Cox $150 in cash in a parking lot. She asked for a good review and left. The room cost almost as much. Add the decoy, and you've spent three keyboards' worth of money to steal one keyboard.

Then, a new email, all staff: an asset audit. Every keyboard, every monitor, every stapler, scanned and logged.

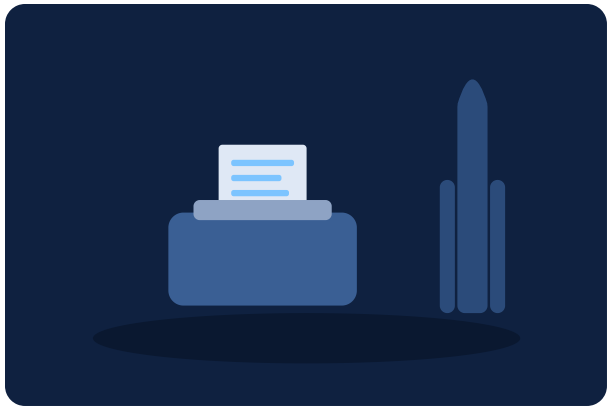
Every keyboard is tagged. Your decoy isn't. The moment anyone scans it, it's over. You have exactly one day.

What will you do?

Make a tag. TURN TO 24

Skip it. Nobody checks. TURN TO 18

Section 49



Take the printer-driver ticket.

“Printer won’t print. Crew building. Urgent.” Every IT person in Florida has scrolled past it. You take it. You fly down with your mom, who is listed as your assistant and has packed sandwiches.

It’s the worst printer driver you have ever installed. It takes four hours. For the first time in your career, you don’t hate it.

The printer prints the crew’s checklists. Everyone thanks you. Nobody takes back your badge.

IT can go anywhere. Nobody asks why. Not even at NASA. On launch morning, nobody asks why you and your mom are in the capsule, either.

What will you do?

Find somewhere to hide. TURN TO 29

Section 50



Go in at closing time.

At 4:55 you're in the museum, studying a spacesuit very hard. At five, the lights dim.

The guard knows your mom. She asks about his grandkids. He gets out his phone. She says "Oh, look at him" forty-one times.

You have the whole museum to yourself. You lift the glass. Somehow you thought the Moon would be heavier.

On the way out, your mom hugs the guard. He tells her to come back soon. She says she will. She probably will.

What will you do?

Get it home. TURN TO 27

Section 51



Call in sick Friday.

You call in sick. Daniel sends soup. Forty people sign a card. Marcy, Daniel's assistant, brings the plaque to your apartment herself and stays for an hour to tell you about her cat.

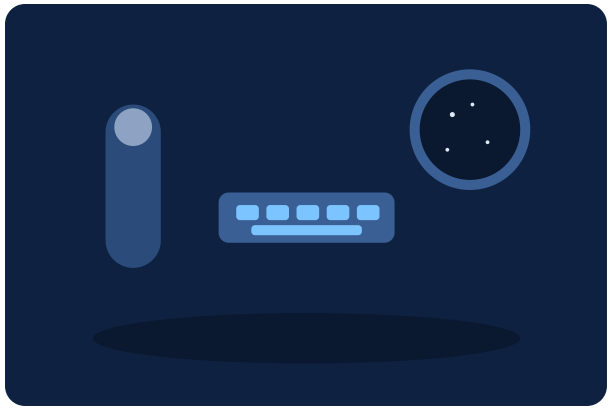
You have never been so celebrated. You have never been so bored.

On Monday, the plaque is on your desk and the soup is in your fridge. Somebody should say thank you.

What will you do?

Go thank Daniel for the soup. TURN TO 34

Section 52



Wait until they sleep.

Astronauts sleep in bags strapped to the walls. You wait until all four are breathing slowly. Your mom gives you a thumbs-up.

You push off toward the keyboard. You push off a little too hard.

You sail past it, spin, and kick something behind a panel. It makes a noise like a blender eating a spoon. Then it makes no noise at all.

You peel the keyboard off the wall. Velcro is very loud at night. The lights come on.

What will you do?

Hide it behind your back. TURN TO 64

Section 53



Go in with a school field trip.

Your mom signs you both up to chaperone a fourth-grade field trip. Nobody checks. Nobody ever checks the chaperones.

Thirty kids hit the museum at once. One tries to climb into a space capsule. Two start crying. The guard runs toward the crying.

Your mom swaps the moon rock for a rock from her garden. Same size. Same gray. She practiced on the kitchen table. You know a decoy when you see one.

On the bus home, a fourth grader asks what's in her purse. "A rock," she says. It's true.

What will you do?

Get it home. TURN TO 27

Section 54



Tell them everything.

So you tell them. Not the joke version, the real one: the plateau, the months of nothing especially wrong and nothing especially interesting, the way even Employee of the Month didn't touch it. All of it.

Jordan doesn't laugh, not even a little, which by now you'd expect. They just nod, slowly, like you've handed them a much heavier box than they were expecting.

"So that's what was wrong with you," they say. Not unkindly.

"That's what's wrong with me," you start to say. Then: "Was."

Congratulations. You found love. You are no longer bored, worried about tickets, or stuck on the plateau...

The end.

ENDING: THE ONE WHO DIDN'T LAUGH

Start over at Section 1.

Section 55



Give it back before morning.

You walk it back before morning. The nice demon lights up so hard their tail knocks over a chair. “You were testing it? For the Pitchfork Safety Committee? Nobody ever volunteers!”

Compliance has already written your name down. The committee meets every Tuesday, forever. Somebody has to take the minutes. It’s you. It will always be you.

What will you do?

Take the minutes. TURN TO 40

Section 56



Hide in the cargo.

Two crates are marked “Crew supplies.” You and your mom are crew supplies now. She packs sandwiches.

A forklift lifts you. A truck drives you somewhere flat and hot. An elevator goes up for a very long time.

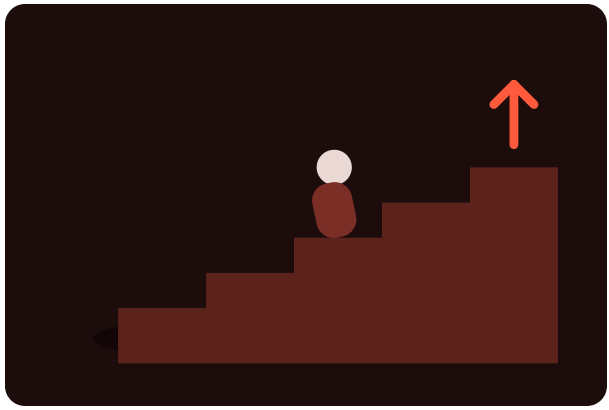
Hours later, you lift the lid an inch. You’re inside the capsule. Next to you, your mom’s lid lifts an inch too.

Four astronauts climb in and strap down. Nobody checks the crew supplies. Somewhere far below, someone starts a countdown.

What will you do?

Stay very still. TURN TO 29

Section 57



Run back up and face it.

You run back up, past the B2 that doesn't exist, and come out by the fern at 8:59 the next morning. The auditor is fine. He's also very clear about who ran.

HR is waiting. Daniel looks so disappointed you almost feel something. Security takes the keyboard and walks you out.

You went back to face it. You're just a day late, and nobody up here gives points for that.

The end.

ENDING: NOT THE HERO

Start over at Section 1.

Section 58



The grandmother

You can't steal it at the retreat. A cabin in the woods, forty coworkers, nowhere to hide. Once the keyboard leaves the building, it's gone.

The retreat has to be canceled. You can't cancel it. Daniel can.

Daniel hates leaving anyone out. Last year he canceled the retreat because one intern was allergic to the trees at the cabin.

All you need is a reason you can't go. A sick relative. You have a mother in Ohio, who is fine and picks up her phone. Or you could hire a grandmother.

You post an ad: "Small family role. Elderly woman. $75/hour. No questions." Three people reply. The first is a college student in a wig. They probably thought it was for a play. The second is a real grandmother, so old she doesn't even know how to improvise a lie.

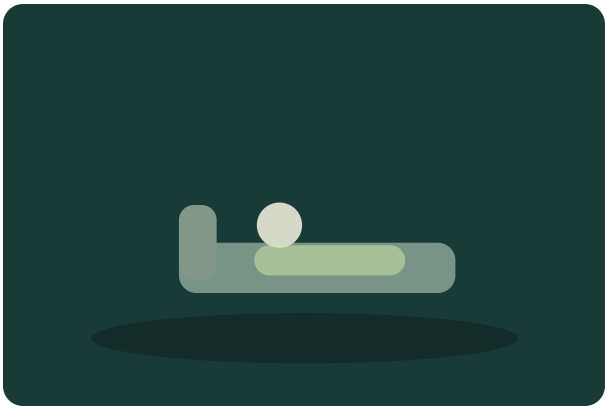
The third introduces herself as Mrs. Cox. She reads the brief, asks about your childhood, and tears up. You haven't told her anything yet.

What will you do?

Hire Mrs. Cox. TURN TO 63

Forget it. Use your mother in Ohio. TURN TO 12

Section 59



Take the sabbatical.

Six weeks, paid. You buy nothing. You go nowhere. You lie on the couch and wait to feel rested.

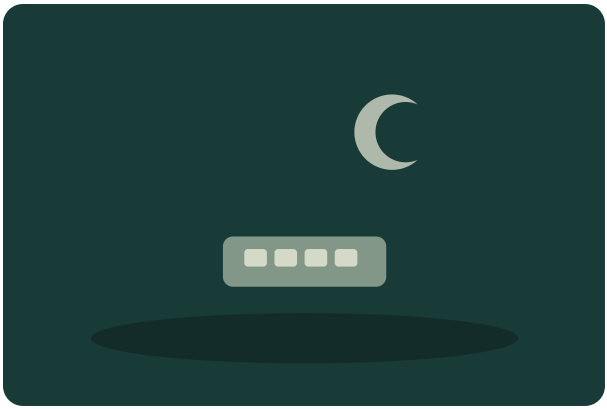
On day thirteen, you catch yourself typing on the arm of the couch. Your fingers know exactly which keyboard they think it is.

On day fourteen, you email Daniel that you're feeling much better. You aren't. You're just feeling something.

What will you do?

Go back early. TURN TO 72

Section 60



The founding keyboard

He hands it over like a sleeping baby. You carry it home in both hands. It has typed a thousand invoices. You plug it in at the kitchen table.

You type your name. It's a keyboard. By the door, in your bag, its twin sits in silence. You now own two of the same keyboard. Neither feels like anything.

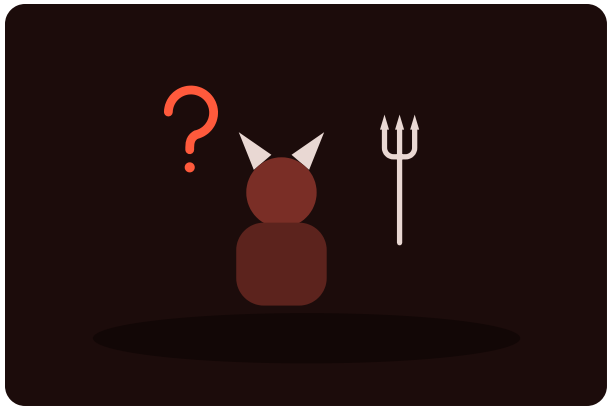
The worst part is that he gave it to you. You had a whole plan. You feel worse than if you'd stolen it.

At 2:14 a.m. you wake up. Something in the kitchen is typing.

What will you do?

Go look. TURN TO 31

Section 61



Just ask for it.

You just ask. It's the most honest you've been in weeks. The nice demon lights up. "Of course! Gosh! Let me check something."

They come back slower. "Whoever a demon gives their pitchfork to, for keeps, does that demon's job. It's in the bylaws. Mine is printer drivers. Every driver that won't install, anywhere."

What will you do?

SIN **Say no thanks. Steal it at the huddle.** TURN TO 70

VIRTUE **Say no thanks. Let them keep it.** TURN TO 35

Section 62



Let Mrs. Cox keep going.

You let Mrs. Cox keep going. She is not a woman who stops. She tells Daniel he reminds her of her late husband, Walter.

By Friday, Daniel has given her the guest room. By Monday, she is at the all-hands, taking notes.

She catches your eye across the conference table and mouths: “You owe me.” She is not wrong.

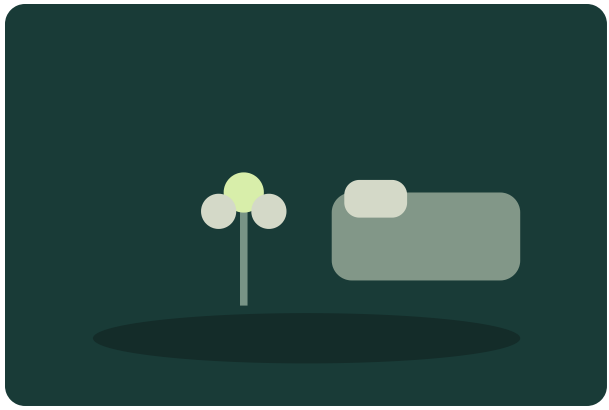
Nobody else knows. You never get near the keyboard again.

Every ending is another beginning.

DEAD END: METHOD

Try a different choice. TURN BACK TO 63

Section 63



The visit

You tell Daniel your grandmother is very sick and you can't make the retreat. You look at the floor. You're better at this than you should be.

He puts a hand over his heart. "Then we're not going. Nobody gets left out." Then he asks where she is. He'd like to visit.

Daniel arrives with flowers and a casserole. Mrs. Cox is propped up in a bed you rented by the hour. She knows your middle name. She knows your childhood dog's name. You don't remember telling her.

Daniel takes her hand and prays. She squeezes back. She's crying real tears. "You're a good grandkid," she says to you. She means it more than you can bear.

He sends the email: "Family comes first. The retreat is canceled. Please keep our teammate's grandmother in your prayers." Marcy replies all with a heart. Forty people follow.

What will you do?

Pay her and move on. TURN TO 48

Let Mrs. Cox keep going. TURN TO 62

Section 64



The toilet

The toilet is broken. It cost twenty-three million dollars. Its fan is jammed. Nobody says whose fault it is. Nobody has to.

Houston says it will still take one kind of business. Not the other kind. Four astronauts look at you. It's a long way home.

The keyboard is behind your back. Your mom is looking at a small hatch you never noticed before. A label on it says ESCAPE POD. It isn't in any of the brochures.

You're IT. Broken things come to you.

What will you do?

Grab your mom. Take the escape pod. TURN TO 17

Put the keyboard back. Fix the toilet. TURN TO 5

Section 65



The outage

Daniel leaves for a meeting. His office is empty. You make it to the doorway. Marcy looks up. You crouch and examine a cable that doesn't exist. "Everything okay?" "Cable." She nods. Cables are a thing.

The next day, you take down the internet for "an emergency patch." The building goes quiet, then loud. Ten people wander toward your desk holding their laptops like sick pets.

Marcy, who lives in her inbox, comes down herself. You tell her it'll be back in two minutes. She thanks you. She goes to the break room for a snack.

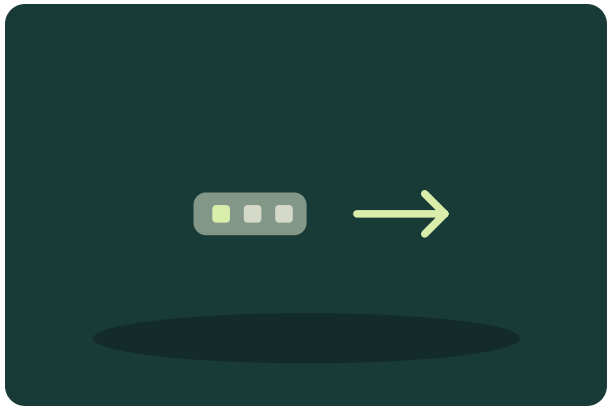
You have two minutes. You walk into Daniel's office. The keyboard is right there.

Next to it, on paper, because the internet is down: his retreat packing list. "Keyboard" is underlined twice.

What will you do?

Back out. Think. TURN TO 58

Section 66



Say “thank you” and sit down.

You say thank you. You sit down. There is a tray of granola bars. There is nothing else.

You eat two. You have never felt so appreciated. You have never felt so far away.

Afterward, Daniel catches you by the elevator. “Come by my office before you go. I have something for you. It’s a granola bar.”

What will you do?

Head to his office. TURN TO 34

Section 67



Save it as a draft.

You save it as a draft. It joins fourteen others. The oldest is from 2021 and just says “Dear Daniel,” which is somehow the saddest one.

It wasn’t quitting you liked. It was the feeling. You’ve only had it one other time lately, with your hands on a keyboard that wasn’t yours.

What will you do?

Look it up. TURN TO 72

Section 68



Get a drink after work.

The bar is loud enough that you don't have to fill every silence. Jordan orders something with too many syllables. You order a beer.

They ask what you actually do, since "IT Support Manager" apparently explains nothing. You tell them about the ticket queue, the passwords, the printer that hates everyone equally.

You almost tell them what the joke at the ceremony actually meant. You get as far as "It's not really a joke. It's more like" and then stop, because you don't know how to finish that sentence without sounding insane.

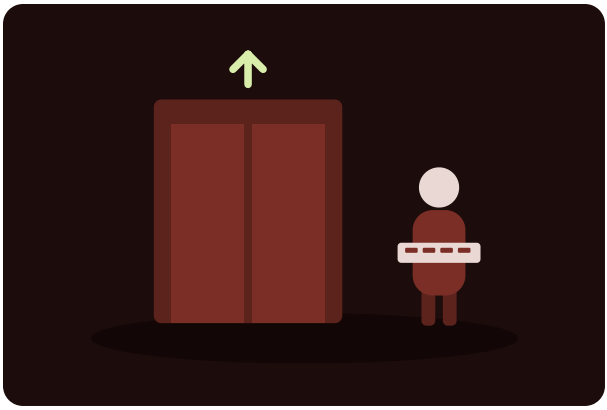
"Like what?" they ask. "Nothing," you say. "Long week." They let it go, which you notice, and like.

Two hours later you're still there. Neither of you has checked a phone once.

What will you do?

See them again. TURN TO 44

Section 69



Say no. Give it all back.

“No,” you say. “It’s theirs.” You hold up the keyboard. “And this isn’t mine. I stole it from a very nice man, then left another man on the floor.”

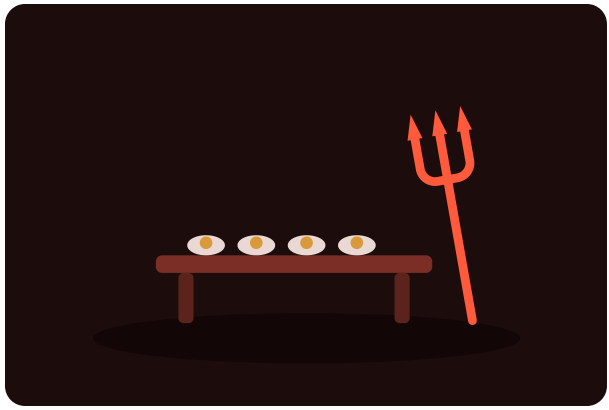
Nobody has ever turned the Devil down to give something back. There isn’t a form for it. The front desk calls: too good for Hell. They send you up the express elevator, keyboard and all.

On your way out, the Devil hands the pitchfork back to the nice demon. They hug it. Then they hug you. It takes a while.

What will you do?

Get in the elevator. TURN TO 13

Section 70



Say no thanks. Steal it at the huddle.

The count goes by serial number, so you scratch one into the decoy: theirs, one digit changed. You've done this before.

At the huddle, the nice demon hugs forty demons, one at a time. On hug forty, you swap. You walk away at a normal speed, which is the hardest thing you've ever done.

The decoy passes. Then the nice demon looks at it. "This isn't mine. It doesn't feel like mine." Compliance: "Transfer offense. Up. Middle management. Ohio."

They hug you goodbye. You have the thing you wanted, and nobody left to show it to.

What will you do?

Take it to Lost and Found. TURN TO 46

Section 71



Confess on Form 666. Bring them back.

At Requisitions, window 4, a demon slides you Form 666: Request for Reinstatement (Pronged). Nine hundred pages. Page one asks for your printer model.

Section 400 asks why, in a box the size of a stamp. You write “x factor.” You erase it. You write “I took it.”

Window 4 stamps it PENDING. It will be pending for as long as Hell has windows.

What will you do?

Wait. TURN TO 40

Section 72



The plan

You can't stop thinking about the keyboard. Dinner, TV, the usual nothing. Except your fingers keep typing on the couch cushion.

You look it up. Full-size. Black and gray. $149.99. Four and a half stars. One reviewer wrote, "It's a keyboard." You buy one.

It arrives in a box big enough for a small pizza. You type your name at the kitchen table. Nothing. Same model, same clack. It has to be his. Some of his soul got into that one, or something. An x factor you cannot explain, and it draws you. Well. Now you have a decoy.

You're early the next morning. You open a spreadsheet. Column A: Daniel's schedule. Column B: Things that could go wrong. It's the most alive you've felt in months, and it's a crime. Or it will be.

IT can go anywhere. Nobody asks why. Daniel eats lunch at 12:15 and leaves his door open. Always. His assistant, Marcy, sits outside it and sees everything.

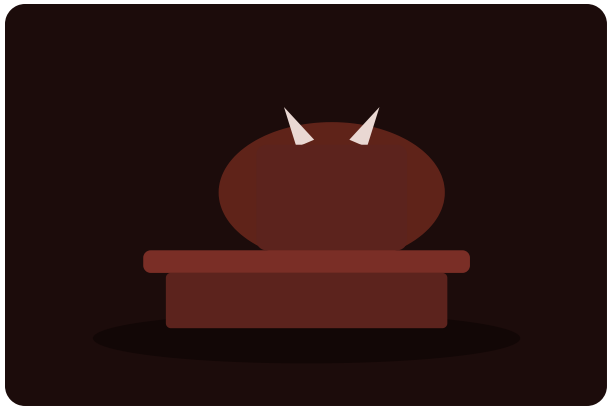
Over her shoulder, her calendar: the company retreat, next Friday. Daniel brings his own keyboard to every offsite. She calls it "the founding keyboard." He started the company on it. Once it leaves the building, it's gone.

What will you do?

Case the office. TURN TO 65

Just ask him about it. TURN TO 25

Section 73



The corner office

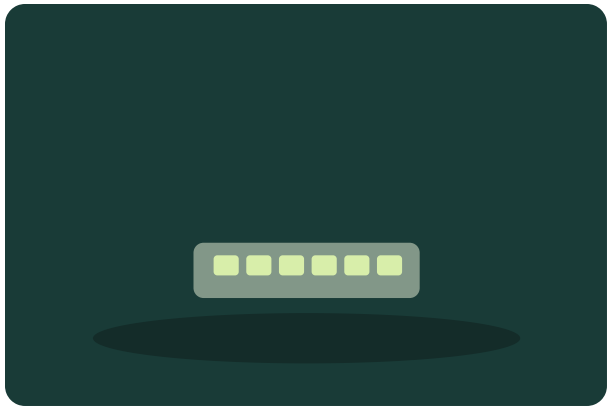
The Devil's door is always open. You ask him to sign the pitchfork over to you, for keeps. Your soul in exchange, if that's still how it works.

He scrolls through your soul for a long time. "It's mostly Outlook," he says, not unkindly. His eyes drift to the keyboard under your arm.

What will you do?

- SIN **Sell him Daniel's keyboard.** — TURN TO 6
- VIRTUE **Refuse. Walk out.** — TURN TO 40

Section 74



Ask him to show you.

He holds out his hand for the decoy in your bag. He knew about it the whole time. He taps it twice and hands it back.

That's the whole spell. No chanting. Nothing catches fire.

That night your keyboard types on its own. In the morning there's money in an account you never opened, from a company that doesn't exist.

You never fix another printer. You never open another ticket. You wake up with nothing to do and nothing wrong, and you smile the way Daniel smiles.

Danal hasn't felt a single thing in centuries. He's never noticed.

Neither will you.

The end.

ENDING: ELEVEN YEARS

Start over at Section 1.

There are eleven real endings. How many have you found?

- [ ] The plateau
- [ ] A little spice
- [ ] The far side
- [ ] Not the hero
- [ ] Driver unavailable
- [ ] The lower plateau
- [ ] Lost and found
- [ ] Your own keyboard
- [ ] Eleven years
- [ ] The first no
- [ ] The one who didn’t laugh

Start over at Section 1.